

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 492

By Sparks

A RESOLUTION to recognize and commend Mary Patterson Watkins.

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should salute those citizens who, through their extraordinary efforts, have distinguished themselves as community leaders of whom we can all be proud; and

WHEREAS, one such noteworthy person is Mary Patterson Watkins, who has distinguished herself as a citizen of the greatest dedication, ability, and integrity; and

WHEREAS, born in Rutherford County, Ms. Watkins is the daughter of Walter Patterson and Sam Ella Patterson; she graduated with a Bachelor of Science in Art and Sociology from Middle Tennessee State University, in addition to gaining two endorsements in special education from the University of Tennessee at Nashville and the University of Tennessee at Martin; and

WHEREAS, dedicating herself to the service of education both in the classroom and in the board room, Ms. Watkins was named the Teacher of the Year for both Riverdale High School and Rutherford County Schools and was employed by the Tennessee Department of Intellectual and Developmental Disabilities for twenty-three years; she retired as a teacher with sixteen years of service; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Watkins's outstanding performance in the classroom was also recognized by "Who's Who Among High School Teachers," and she received the Trailblazer in Education Award from Middle Tennessee State University and the *Daily News Journal*; and

WHEREAS, eager for the continued success of her students, Ms. Watkins was instrumental in the creation of the Rutherford County Transition Academy at Middle Tennessee

State University, and she developed Profiles for Athletes to assist students in leveraging their athletic abilities to secure college scholarships; and

WHEREAS, no stranger to accolades, she has earned myriad recognitions and awards for her many and varied accomplishments: Resolution for Extraordinary Service and Leadership in Rutherford County from the Rutherford County Board of Commissioners in 2025, the African American Heritage Society Founders Award in 2024, the Tennessee Historical Commission Certificate of Merit in 2024, the Murfreesboro Muslim Youth Person of the Year Award in 2023, the Leading Ladies Project Historian for the Party of Twelve Play in 2022, the Rutherford County Heritage Society Community Service Award in 2021, the Unity Luncheon Unsung Hero Award in African American Arts at Middle Tennessee State University in 2018, a profile in the creative journal *Collage* titled "From MTSU Student to Community Icon" in 2020, the NAACP Woman of the Year Award in 2015, and the Recognition Award from the Department of Education, Division of College and Career Readiness in 2011; and

WHEREAS, Ms. Watkins, keenly understanding the power of history, helped found the African American Heritage Society of Rutherford County, which seeks to discover, preserve, and teach the African-American story in Rutherford County, and its efforts have resulted in the installation of three Tennessee Historical Markers, the erection of four monuments, the mounting of a plaque, and the consideration of six other possible historical marker sites; and

WHEREAS, she has also been a genealogy instructor at the Patterson Community Center for "African American Voices: Past and Present of Rutherford County" since 2012, and she utilizes her superlative skills as a public speaker on various topics for her local community; and

WHEREAS, multivalent in her talent, she is a skilled artist, an expertise that she shares with her neighbors through helping at youth art camps and senior art activities; acting as a

sketch artist for the Murfreesboro Discovery Center on Martin Luther King, Jr., Day; presenting art exhibits at schools and other community events; and donating art for local fundraisers; and

WHEREAS, her creative facility also extends to the written word; she is both a playwright and a director of plays and skits, which have been performed at such locations as the Patterson Center, Riverdale High School, Stones River National Battlefield, and Bethel Missionary Baptist Church; and

WHEREAS, her renowned historical sensibility and care are well employed on the advisory board for the Oakland Mansion and as a commissioner for the Rutherford County Courthouse Museum; and

WHEREAS, additionally, Ms. Watkins served as the guest speaker at Representative Mike Sparks' Rutherford County History discussion at the Sam Davis Home; and

WHEREAS, thoughtful of both this world and the next, Ms. Watkins is a lifelong member of Bethel Missionary Baptist Church in Walter Hill; and

WHEREAS, Mary Watkins epitomizes the spirit and commitment that are characteristic of a true Tennessean, and she should be specially recognized for her many accomplishments and devoted work; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor and commend Mary Patterson Watkins for her selfless service to her fellow citizens and extend to her our best wishes for continued success and happiness in all her future endeavors.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.

